

How To Write It Differently — A Client-Facing Masterclass

Why everyone sounds the same, the four moves that fix it, and a live before → after clinic. Aimed at a client-facing role at Goldman.

The one idea to hold onto

Writing "differently" is not a vocabulary trick. It is a *substance* trick.

People think standing out means fancier words — "leverage," "passionate," "dynamic." It doesn't. Two candidates using identical plain words can be worlds apart: one is generic, one is unforgettable. The difference is always the same thing —

How specific and how honest is the substance underneath the sentence?

Generic = true of anyone, about any bank. Differentiated = could *only* have been written by you, about *only* Goldman. That's it. Everything below is just how to get there.

Part 1 — Why everyone sounds the same

Almost every applicant makes the same three default moves without realising it. Learn to spot them — in your own draft — and you're already ahead:

1. **They claim traits.** "I have strong interpersonal skills, I'm a team player, I thrive under pressure." → Anyone can *type* these. Zero evidence. Invisible.
2. **They praise the firm.** "Goldman is a prestigious, world-leading firm with an amazing culture." → Flattery every applicant writes. Swap in any bank's name — still works. Dead.
3. **They restate the CV.** "During my internship at X I developed skills in Y." → The reader already has your CV. This adds nothing.

Here is the uncomfortable truth: **95% of applicants write some blend of these three, so the bar to stand out is genuinely low.** You don't need to be a genius writer. You need to *not* do these three things — and do the four moves instead.

Part 2 — The four moves (this is the method)

Learn these four. Every strong sentence uses at least one. This is the whole craft.

Move 1 — The Swap Test (kill the generic)

For every sentence, ask: "If I swapped 'Goldman' for 'Morgan Stanley', or swapped *me* for any other applicant — would this still read perfectly?" If yes, it's generic. Delete or rescue it. - ❌ "I want to work at

Goldman because of its world-class reputation." (true of any bank, written by anyone) - The fix is always the same: **add substance until it can only be about you and only about Goldman.**

Move 2 — Show, Don't Tell (claim → evidence)

Never state a quality. **Prove it with a specific thing you did**, and let the reader conclude the quality themselves. This is exactly what Sam teaches for CV bullets — "detail is how you demonstrate skill implicitly." - ❌ "I'm great with people / a natural relationship-builder." - ✅ [a specific 15-second story where you did something that *shows* it — see the clinic below] - The reader thinking "*this person is good with people*" is 100× more powerful than you *saying* it.

Move 3 — Concrete-First (open on a moment, not an abstraction)

Start sentences and paragraphs with a **specific image, moment, or detail** — not a general statement. Concrete is memorable; abstract is wallpaper. - ❌ "I have always been fascinated by financial markets." - ✅ "The £[X] I put into [specific stock] after [specific reason] taught me more than any lecture..."

Move 4 — The Theme → Me Mirror (their DNA = how you already operate)

This is the highest-level move, and it's the engine of Sam's Optiver letter. Take something the firm genuinely values, then show **you already think/work that way** — with evidence. You're not saying "I admire your culture"; you're saying "*the way I already operate is the way you operate.*" - Structure: **[specific thing you observed the firm values] + [specific evidence you already live it].**

Plus one rule that governs all four — go one level down. Never write "Goldman's culture." Write about the *specific* thing (a desk, a client dynamic, a way of working) you actually saw. "Culture" is abstract; "the way the sales desk described conducting research, execution and prime as one instrument for the client" is concrete. Specific always beats general.

Part 3 — The client-facing culture material (curated from your event)

You want client-facing. Good — the event was *full* of the real thing, and most applicants write about it badly. Here's what client-facing actually is at Goldman, the generic thing people say about it, and the differentiated angle you can build on.

The big reframe most people miss: amateurs think client-facing = "I'm a people person, I'm charismatic, people like me." Goldman's own people describe it completely differently — and *far* more sophisticatedly. Master this distinction and you already sound different:

What everyone writes	What the event actually revealed (your edge)
"I'm a people person / good with clients."	Mini: the job is <i>"understand what makes clients look smart to their own bosses."</i> Client service isn't being liked — it's making the <i>other</i> person succeed internally.
"I love building relationships."	Mini's proof: her best client relationship began when they were both juniors doing end-of-day trade bookings — relationships that compound start at your own level, <i>now</i> .
"I'm a strong communicator."	Jessica: research is <i>"one of the most client-facing jobs in the bank,"</i> and the best analysts are <i>"really good listeners"</i> — a <i>sounding board</i> , not a broadcaster. Listening > talking.
"I want to give great client service."	Jack: when you leave a client meeting, ask <i>"what did they want from that meeting? how can we add value to what they do?"</i> — service is a discipline of <i>their</i> goals, not your pitch.
"I can build rapport quickly."	Jack: he pitches <i>"a conversation, not an idea"</i> — the skill is engaging someone in what <i>they</i> care about today. Shash: the client-service rep is <i>"your people on the inside"</i> — the fixer who parachutes in and drives it to resolution.
"I'd love a long career here."	Shash: <i>"the analyst you're chatting to may be a COO in ten years."</i> Jack: clients became wedding guests, a godfather to his child. The relationship <i>is</i> the career.

Which client-facing seats this points at (so you can aim the division-specific half): **Sales & Sales Trading** (Global Banking & Markets), **Wealth Management** (Asset & Wealth Management), and **Research** (yes — it's client-facing, per Jessica). The culture material above is firm-level and works across all of them; you tailor only the desk-specific beat.

Part 4 — THE CLINIC (before → after)

This is where you learn by watching the moves happen. Same idea, written the generic way, then rebuilt. Study *why* each one changes. (The "after" versions use **[bracketed placeholders]** — that's where *your* real facts go. I'm teaching the shape, not fabricating your life.)

Clinic 1 — "Why I want a client-facing role"

✗ Generic: *"I'm a strong communicator and a people person, so I'd thrive in a client-facing role at a top firm like Goldman."* - **Diagnosis:** claims two traits (Move 2 fail), praises the firm generically (Move 1 fail), abstract (Move 3 fail). Swap-test: works for any candidate at any bank. Invisible.

✓ Differentiated: *"At the equities panel, Mini said the job isn't being liked — it's understanding what makes a client look smart to their own boss. That reframed something I'd felt but never named: [the moment you realised helping someone succeed to their boss/teacher/manager mattered more than being liked — e.g. how you handled a customer/teammate/committee]."* - **Moves used:** concrete-first (opens on the specific panel moment), theme → me mirror (her insight → your lived evidence), and it's swap-proof (only true of you, only from this event). The reader concludes *"this person actually understands client work"* — you never had to claim it.

Clinic 2 — "Why Goldman"

✗ **Generic:** "Goldman is a world-leading firm with an incredible culture and brand, and I'd be honoured to be part of it." - **Diagnosis:** pure flattery. Swap in "J.P. Morgan" — identical. This sentence is *actively* a red flag: it signals you have nothing specific.

✓ **Differentiated:** "What struck me at the insight day was how the sales, research, execution and prime teams each described their job as playing one instrument for the client — Jack literally called the salesperson 'the conductor of the orchestra.' I hadn't understood before that Goldman's edge is the integration, not any single desk — and that's exactly the kind of connective role I'm drawn to, because [specific evidence you're the person who pulls pieces/people together]." - **Moves used:** one-level-down (the "conductor" specific, not "culture"), theme → me mirror, concrete-first. Un-swappable — it's Goldman's own language, from the room you were in.

Clinic 3 — "Show don't tell" on relationship-building

✗ **Generic:** "I have excellent interpersonal skills and always build strong relationships."

✓ **Differentiated (the trick is to tell a 15-second story and stop):** "[The teammate/customer/regular who was difficult, and the specific small thing you did — remembered their name, solved the thing they actually needed, made them look good — and what it became over time.]" - **Why it works:** the reader watches you build a relationship and concludes the trait themselves. It also quietly mirrors Mini's "relationships that compound start early" and Shash's "remember names." You proved three things without claiming one.

Clinic 4 — "Show don't tell" on genuine markets interest (the passion test)

✗ **Generic:** "I am deeply passionate about financial markets and follow them closely." - **Diagnosis:** the single most-written sentence in finance. Means nothing.

✓ **Differentiated:** "[What you genuinely read/listen to] + [the £X you actually invested in [specific thing] and your real reasoning] — [and a specific market question you've been chewing on, e.g. one from the event: whether the market is really under-pricing the seismic-data bottleneck Jack described]." - **Why it works:** Sunil said he asks every candidate "what do you read?" and Guillaume asks "do you invest even £20?" — you're *passing the actual test* with evidence instead of claiming the trait. Un-fakeable because it's true.

Part 5 — Your repeatable recipe (do this every time)

1. **Brain-dump ugly and honest first.** Write why you want this in plain, messy words — no trying to sound good. Truth first, polish later.
 2. **Pick ONE client-facing theme** from Part 3 that is genuinely you (don't pick the one that sounds most impressive — pick the one you can back with real evidence).
 3. **Find your evidence** — one specific 15-second story from your life that *shows* it (Move 2). This is the hardest and most important step. It doesn't have to be finance: a job, a team, a customer, a society role.
 4. **Open concrete** (Move 3) — start on the event moment or the evidence, never on "I have always...".
 5. **Run every sentence through the Swap Test** (Move 1). Cut anything that survives it. Then read it aloud — if it sounds like a robot or a brochure, rewrite it as you'd actually say it (GS screens for AI/generic — your natural voice is the goal).
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Part 6 — The red-flag self-edit checklist

Before you submit, delete or rewrite any sentence that: - ☐ survives the Swap Test (works for another bank / another candidate) - ☐ **claims** a trait instead of showing it ("I am hardworking/personable/driven") - ☐ praises Goldman's "prestige / reputation / world-class culture" - ☐ restates something already on your CV - ☐ says "passionate about finance" (or any version of it) - ☐ mentions money, prestige, or exit opportunities - ☐ could have been written by someone who *didn't* attend your event - ☐ sounds like ChatGPT rather than like you talking

If a sentence trips none of these, keep it. That's the whole test.

Part 7 — Your blank scaffold (structure only — you write the words)

A ~300-word client-facing statement, built from the moves. I'm giving you the *frame and the job of each beat* — not the sentences.

- **Beat 1 — Concrete hook (2–3 sentences).** Open on the single client-facing moment from the event that genuinely landed for you (Mini's "make clients look smart," Jack's "conductor / pitch a conversation," Jessica's "listening"). *Move used: concrete-first.*
- **Beat 2 — Theme → Me (the core).** Name what that revealed about client work at Goldman, then prove *you already operate that way* with ONE specific story. *Move used: theme → me mirror + show-don't-tell.* ← spend the most words here.
- **Beat 3 — Why this desk (the tailored bit).** One division-specific line — a real Sales/Sales-Trading/Wealth dynamic or a deal/theme from the event — re-pointed per application. *Move used: one-level-down.*
- **Beat 4 — Close (1 sentence, your voice).** Why Goldman specifically, genuine, no adjectives, no prestige.

Reflection prompts to fill it (be honest — the honesty is the differentiation): - When have you made someone *else* succeed — helped them look good to *their* boss/teacher/team — rather than seeking credit yourself? (Mini) - When were you the "fixer" people came to when something went wrong? (Shash) - When did *listening* — not talking — solve something? (Jessica) - What relationship of yours grew because you invested in it early, before it was "useful"? (Mini/Jack) - What do you genuinely read/follow, and what have you actually invested in? (the passion test)

What I need to finish this *with* you

I've taught you the method and given you the client-facing raw material. The one thing I can't invent is **your evidence** — the specific stories in Beat 2 that make it un-fakeable. So:

1. Send me your **CV / background** (experiences, the client-facing or people-facing moments — retail, teams, societies, anything).
2. Tell me **which client-facing seat** you're aiming at first (Sales & Sales Trading, Wealth Management, or Research).
3. Answer even one or two of the reflection prompts above with a real story.

Then we do it together: you give me the honest raw material, I show you how to run it through the four moves, and *you* write the final version in your own voice — which, by then, will genuinely sound like no one else's.